

state had a special relationship with Britain, because its prince had been designated as Protestant heir to the British throne. Almost immediately, Handel took a long leave of absence in London and soon abandoned the Hanoverian court altogether, seduced by the musical and financial opportunities the British capital offered. He was to live there for the rest of his life.

In London, Italian opera was the height of fashion and Handel's *Rinaldo*, staged at the Queen's Theatre in 1711, introduced him to his new country as a master of the genre. The composer ingratiated himself with the British aristocracy, earning the patronage of the earl of Burlington and the duke of Chandos. He also curried favor with Queen Anne, receiving a royal pension after writing music for the celebration of the Peace of Utrecht that ended war with France in 1714.

Anne's death in the same year brought the accession of Handel's Hanoverian employer as King George I. This was a potentially tricky moment for Handel, since he had abandoned Hanover without permission, but the king did not bear a grudge. In 1717, Londoners were treated to the spectacle of King George drifting down the Thames accompanied by 50 musicians in a barge playing music specially composed by Handel for the occasion—the three suites known as the Water Music.